Freeing up disk space on your laptop

Article KB0010043 | Owner: Service Desk L1 | Subcategory: Low disk space | Applies to: Windows?11 23H2/24H2 (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS?14/15 (MacBook Pro/Air)

Summary

This article guides users through checking and reclaiming disk space on their Acme-Global laptops running Windows?11 or macOS. It provides a simple self-help routine using built-in tools (Storage Sense, Disk Cleanup, or macOS storage management) and outlines the steps the Service Desk L1 team follows when a ticket is raised, including verification and escalation criteria.

Symptoms

- Low disk space warning pop-up
- "Cannot save files - disk full" error when trying to save or download
- File Explorer shows the C: drive (or Macintosh HD) at 90%+ usage
- Storage Sense notification: "You're running low on disk space"

Common causes

- Accumulation of temporary files, browser caches, and Windows Update cleanup leftovers
- Large personal files (videos, ISO images, project archives) stored locally instead of OneDrive
- Multiple versions of Windows feature updates retained in the WinSxS folder
- macOS system caches, old iOS backups, and large download folders

Self-Help Procedure

Follow these steps to quickly free space on your laptop. The process works for both Windows and macOS; choose the subsection that matches your OS. Completing the steps usually recovers 10-30?GB, enough to resume normal work.

1. Windows?11:
2. 1. Open Settings -> System -> Storage. Turn on Storage Sense if it is off.
3. 2. Click Configure Storage Sense or run it now. Set it to delete temporary files that haven't been used in the last 1 day and to empty the Recycle Bin after 14 days.
4. 3. Press Run Storage Sense now and wait for it to finish (usually a few minutes).
5. 4. Still in Settings -> System -> Storage, click Show more categories -> Temporary files. Select items such as Windows Update Cleanup, Downloads, and Thumbnails, then click Remove files.
6. 5. Open File Explorer, right-click the C: drive -> Properties -> Disk Cleanup. Choose Clean up system files, tick Previous Windows installations and Windows Update Cleanup, then OK.
7. 6. Move large personal files (videos, ISO, archives) to OneDrive. In OneDrive settings enable Files On-Demand so they appear online-only unless you need them locally.
8. macOS:
9. 1. Click the Apple menu -> About This Mac -> Storage -> Manage.
10. 2. Review Recommendations: Store in iCloud, Optimize Storage, Empty Trash Automatically, Reduce Clutter. Enable those that suit your workflow.
11. 3. Select Documents -> Large Files to locate items >?GB size; move or delete as appropriate.
12. 4. Open Finder -> Go -> Go to Folder... type ~/Library/Caches and delete contents of folders you recognize (e.g., com.apple.Safari).
13. 5. Check ~/Downloads for old installers or media and remove them.
14. 6. If you use Time Machine locally, consider disabling local snapshots temporarily: open Terminal and run `sudo tmutil disablelocal`. Remember to re-enable after cleanup.

Service-Desk Agent Procedure

When a user reports low disk space, the L1 agent should verify the issue, apply the standard cleanup routine, and confirm that sufficient free space is restored before closing the ticket. The steps below reflect the usual resolution seen in tickets (Storage Sense + temp file cleanup, moving files to OneDrive, removing old Windows update files).

1. 1. Create a ticket in the self-service portal (or accept the incoming call/chat) and categorize it as Hardware -> Low

disk space.
2. 2. Ask the user for the operating system and laptop model to confirm applicable steps.
3. 3. Request the user to open Storage Sense (Windows) or Storage Management (macOS) and run a cleanup while you stay on the call or chat.
4. 4. For Windows devices, guide the user through Settings -> System -> Storage -> Storage Sense -> Run Storage Sense now, then Disk Cleanup with system files selected (Previous Windows installations, Windows Update Cleanup).
5. 5. For macOS devices, guide the user through Apple menu -> About This Mac -> Storage -> Manage and apply the recommendations (Store in iCloud, Optimize Storage, Empty Trash, Reduce Clutter).
6. 6. After cleanup, ask the user to verify free space: Windows - Settings -> System -> Storage; macOS - About This Mac -> Storage. Confirm at least 10?GB free (or the amount needed for the user's work).
7. 7. If the user has large personal files, advise moving them to OneDrive with Files On-Demand enabled, and confirm the move is complete.
8. 8. Close the ticket with a resolution note summarizing actions taken and space recovered (e.g., "Ran Storage Sense and cleared temp files - freed 18?GB; moved 12?GB of video to OneDrive; removed old Windows update files - total 30?GB freed.")

Verification

After completing either the self-help or agent procedure, verify that the disk space issue is resolved and that the system is stable.

1. 1. Re-open the storage overview to confirm the increased free space.
2. 2. Try to save a test file or download a small item to ensure the "disk full" error no longer appears.
3. 3. Check that critical applications (Outlook, Teams, VPN) launch without errors related to insufficient disk space.
4. 4. If the problem persists after the steps, note the remaining used space and any unusual files consuming capacity for further investigation.

When to escalate

Escalate to the Desktop Support group if: the user reports less than 5?GB free after performing the full cleanup, the disk shows signs of hardware failure (SMART errors, slow performance, frequent crashes), or the user needs to move data that exceeds OneDrive storage quota. Include in the escalation: laptop model, OS version, current free/total space, list of largest folders/files (from WinDirStat, TreeSize, or macOS Storage Management), and any error logs from the Event Viewer or Console.

Keywords: disk space, low disk storage, free up space, Storage Sense, Disk Cleanup, OneDrive Files On-Demand, macOS storage management, temporary files, Windows Update Cleanup, C: drive full, Macintosh HD full, cannot save files, Acme laptop cleanup